

5 Reasons You're Still Fat After 40

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Aug 22, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xt2ClKuNe0s> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

27-year personal trainer and 44-year-old Brandon Carter identifies five mistakes keeping men over 40 fat — spanning hormone health, modern pharmacology, calorie tracking, protein intake, and mindset — and gives actionable steps for each.

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Mistake 1: Blaming Your Circumstances [0:22](#)

- Men constantly cite kids, jobs, and busy schedules as reasons they can't stay in shape
 - Carter points out these men are often the same age as him — sometimes younger
 - He runs a multi-million-dollar business with 30 employees, takes 50 flights a year, has a son, and cares for nieces and nephews
 - "They're doing that to make themselves feel better"
- The real underlying issue is hormonal — not time or circumstance
- Note: only 2 of the 5 mistakes involve anything medical; the other 3 cost nothing

Mistake 2: Not Addressing Your Hormones (TRT) [1:08](#)

- After age 30, every man's testosterone drops naturally — approximately **2% per year**
 - Lower testosterone = easier to store fat, harder to hold on to muscle
- Body fat actively makes things worse through a process called **aromatization**
 - Fat converts testosterone into estrogen, dropping testosterone even further
 - This creates a vicious cycle that compounds over a decade or more
- "Calories in, calories out is not the complete picture"
 - A 43-year-old and a 23-year-old eating identical diets will get different results
 - Same math, but different hormonal chemistry

- Analogously, men and women eating the same calories respond differently because the average woman has only ~10% the testosterone of the average man
- Carter got on **testosterone replacement therapy (TRT) just before turning 40**
 - Benefits: more energy, better recovery, feeling like himself again
 - He and his doctor keep his testosterone around **900 ng/dL**
 - In his 20s his testosterone was ~1,200 ng/dL — he doesn't want or need that level now
- **Action steps:**
 - Get a full hormone panel drawn within the next two weeks
 - Must include: total testosterone, free testosterone, and all related markers
 - A basic physical skips all of this — you need a specialist
 - Find a doctor who specializes in men's hormones, not just a general practitioner (or an endocrinologist)
 - If numbers come back low, bring up TRT yourself by name
 - Use real labs and a real doctor — "This isn't a DIY type of thing"

Mistake 3: Not Using a GLP-1 Medication 3:50

- Most men are still dieting like it's 2005, before GLP-1 drugs existed
 - Analogy: dieting without a GLP is like using a library card and the Dewey Decimal System; dieting with one is like using Claude or ChatGPT
 - "There's never been an easier time in history to get ripped than right now because of these drugs"
- Carter is personally on a GLP-1 called **Tirzepatide** (also references "Smoothie" and Zepbound by name)
 - It crushes hunger and makes dieting easy
- **Critical warning — the hidden danger of GLP-1s:**
 - The hard part is no longer fighting cravings; it's remembering to eat at all
 - You can go an entire day without eating and not notice it
 - If you don't consume enough protein while on these medications, you will lose muscle
 - At 40+, muscle is harder to build back — muscle loss is a serious risk
- **Action steps for GLP users:**
 - Set **three alarms** at your normal meal times labeled "Eat protein now"
 - When not hungry, drink a protein shake — do not rely on intuitive eating
 - Do NOT attempt a DIY approach; get it prescribed
 - At the same appointment where you're getting your hormone labs, ask your doctor about Tirzepatide by name

Mistake 4: Not Understanding How Easy It Is to Get Fat (Calorie Tracking) 6:06

- **1 pound of body fat ≈ 3,500 calories**
 - Eating just 200 calories over your burn every day = **20 pounds of fat gained per year**
 - 200 calories is almost nothing: two bananas, a handful of almonds, or a squirt of ranch dressing
- Fat accumulation is gradual and nearly invisible day-to-day — just like watching kids grow

- Most people went from decent shape in their 20s to looking like Homer Simpson without a single dramatic event
- It was a slow, consistent surplus over years, not cake and candy binges
- Every client Carter has trained who tracked calories for the first time was shocked at how much they were eating
 - "Intrinsically, most people have no idea how many calories are in the foods they're eating"
- **Calorie tracking is the single most correlated behavior with being in great shape**
 - "Everybody I've ever met who tracked their calories for a significant amount of time is in amazing shape regardless of age"
 - "Everybody who looks like trash does not track their calories. Success leaves clues."
- **Action steps:**
 - Track calories every single day
 - Use Claude or ChatGPT — take pictures of food or food labels and log them in a pinned chat
 - Carter says this is far easier than MyFitnessPal or similar apps
 - He provides a specific prompt in the video description
 - Business case: Carter built a multi-million-dollar online fitness business largely by making clients track their calories and holding them accountable daily
 - Community member Will — full-time job, kids, wife — got into shape through tracking, then joined Carter's coaching program and made **\$32,000 in his first month** as an online trainer

Mistake 5: Taking Protein Advice from Young Influencers 10:18

- Young fitness influencers often say things like "eat less protein, you'll get ripped" or "you only need 0.8–1.8g of protein to build muscle"
 - Studies they cite are real but were NOT conducted on men in their 40s
- **Anabolic resistance** increases with age
 - The older you get, the harder it is for your body to synthesize protein into muscle
 - Men in their 40s need MORE protein than a 20-year-old just to maintain existing muscle — not even to build new muscle
- **The thermogenic effect of protein is the biggest reason to eat more of it:**

Macronutrient	Calories burned during digestion
Protein	20–30% of calories consumed
Carbohydrates	~10–15% (roughly half of protein)
Fat	~3–5% (roughly one-third of protein)

- Eating 100 calories of protein means your body only absorbs ~70–80 of those calories
- "It's a fat loss cheat code"
- Carter personally eats **250–300 grams of protein per day** at a bodyweight of **195 lbs**
 - Attributes his long-term leanness in large part to this habit

- "What you need and what's optimal are two different things. All you need is food, water, and shelter. We're talking about optimization."
- **Action step:**
 - Eat at least **1 gram of protein per pound of bodyweight every single day** — with no upper ceiling
 - Track it the same way you track calories (in Claude or ChatGPT)

Mistake 6: Accepting Mediocrity 12:17

- Men frame being out of shape as a "tradeoff" for having kids or a career — in reality they have simply accepted mediocre standards for themselves
- Time is almost never the real problem
 - Eating less takes zero additional time — if anything it frees up time
 - Working out requires only **one hour a day, a few days a week** — not seven days a week
 - "I bet if I look at your screen time right now, I could find an extra hour somewhere"
- Carter's personal example:
 - Runs multiple seven-figure businesses, dozens of employees, involved father, 50 flights a year
 - On a week-long Disney cruise with his son, he was in the water doing everything — not parked on the beach
 - At the trampoline park he gets two pairs of socks and jumps with his son; plays dodgeball while other dads sit on the bench
 - "My son didn't tire me out. I tired him out."

"The real reason I stayed in shape for 30 years in a row isn't free time. It's that I hold myself to a different standard."

- **Mediocre Mantras** — Carter's term for the self-sabotaging phrases people use:
 - "One won't hurt"
 - "I deserve this"
 - "I can have a little bit"
 - "I can take the day off"
 - These mantras signal to yourself that inconsistency is acceptable
 - "The reason you're inconsistent is because you accept inconsistency. Once you stop accepting inconsistency, consistency becomes easy."
- Carter has had **zero cheat days or cheat meals in nearly four years**
 - At his son's birthday party he cuts cake for everyone else — and doesn't eat any
 - "Stop trying to see how much you can get away with. Start seeing how much you can push yourself."
- **Action step:** Raise your standards — eliminate mediocre mantras and stop using circumstances as excuses